

“Blasphemy or Truth: Andres Serrano’s Piss Christ and the Limits of Public Art Funding”

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In 1987, photographer Andres Serrano unveiled a small Cibachrome print that would ignite a national firestorm. *Piss Christ* depicts a golden-lit crucifix submerged in the artist's own urine, glowing like a relic encased in amber. Its formal beauty—the soft gradients of orange and red, the serenity of the composition—contrasts sharply with the vulgarity of its medium. When it was exhibited in 1989, senators Jesse Helms and Alfonse D'Amato denounced the work on the Senate floor as an “abomination” funded by taxpayers. What began as a single photograph quickly became a flashpoint in the late-1980s Culture Wars, crystallizing national anxieties about the boundaries of artistic freedom and public morality. Should publicly funded art be limited by moral offense? *Piss Christ*, I argue, reveals how outrage over offensive art often masks a deeper discomfort with pluralism itself. Restricting funding on moral grounds threatens democratic discourse by demanding that art comfort rather than challenge.

The controversy surrounding *Piss Christ* cannot be understood without the political context of the National Endowment for the Arts. Established in 1965, the NEA aimed to democratize access to culture by supporting excellence and diversity in the arts. By the late 1980s, however, it had become a lightning rod for moral panic. Serrano received a modest fellowship through the Awards in the Visual Arts program, a juried grant partially funded by the NEA. Once news spread that the artist's submission involved a crucifix in urine, members of Congress erupted. Historian Roger Chapman notes that “questions of artistic value became inseparable from questions of morality and public virtue.”¹ The uproar reached fever pitch when paired with another scandal: the Cincinnati exhibition of Robert Mapplethorpe's *The Perfect Moment*, which included homoerotic photography. Together, these works became political

¹ Roger Chapman, “Andres Serrano,” in *Culture Wars in America: An Encyclopedia of Issues, Viewpoints, and Voices*, 2nd ed., ed. Roger Chapman and James Ciment (Armonk, NY: M.E. Sharpe, 2010).

symbols of supposed cultural decay. Congressional hearings followed, leading to the NEA's "decency clause," budget cuts, and a chilling effect on public art across the country. As one critic summarized, "Art had become the scapegoat for social anxiety."²

This pattern was not new. Earlier public-art disputes—Richard Serra's *Tilted Arc* (1981) and Maya Lin's *Vietnam Veterans Memorial* (1982)—had likewise provoked outrage for challenging expectations of beauty, patriotism, and decorum. Yet in Serrano's case, the offense was moral rather than aesthetic. The shift from debates about taste to debates about sin marked a turning point in American cultural politics. Art historian Miwon Kwon argues that public art should "intervene rather than integrate."³ *Piss Christ* intervened forcefully, exposing the fragility of a democracy that mistakes consensus for unity.

The irony is that the photograph, viewed without its sensational context, is anything but vulgar. The crucifix appears to float in a soft golden haze; light glows from behind the cross like a halo. The composition recalls the devotional calm of Baroque painting. The shock comes not from what the viewer sees but from what they learn—that the amber medium is urine. Serrano explained that his intention was not blasphemy but critique: to reveal how the sacred had been debased through commercialization.⁴ "I am questioning not religion but the way religion has been commercialized," he told *Art in America* in 1990.⁵ In this reading, the urine stands not for contempt but for contamination—the way mass culture profanes what it claims to adore.

² "NEA Under Siege," *American Theater* 7, no. 3 (1990): 45.

³ Miwon Kwon, *One Place After Another: Site-Specific Art and Locational Identity* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2002), 74.

⁴ Andres Serrano, quoted in Ilan Stavans and Jorge J. E. Gracia, "On Desecration: Andrés Serrano, *Piss Christ*," *Michigan Quarterly Review* 52, no. 4 (2013): 583.

⁵ "Andres Serrano: The Cross and the Body," *Art in America*, April 1990.

Critics who dismissed *Piss Christ* as mere provocation ignored the work's intricate play of reverence and defilement. Philosophers Ilan Stavans and Jorge J. E. Gracia observe that "Serrano transforms profanity into revelation."⁶ The photograph's radiance depends on its impurity; its spiritual charge arises precisely from what should repel us. *Piss Christ* is a meditation on the coexistence of holiness and desecration, not a rejection of faith but an acknowledgment of its vulnerability. As Pope Francis remarked in 2023, "Artists reveal reality also in its contradictions."⁷ Serrano's image shows belief surviving even when submerged in filth.

The fury that met *Piss Christ* stemmed not from misunderstanding alone but from a refusal to accept that contradiction belongs in the public sphere. Senator Helms declared that "taxpayers shouldn't be forced to pay for their own desecration." Yet this complaint mistakes funding for endorsement. Public arts funding is not a stamp of approval but an investment in discourse. In a pluralistic democracy, the government's role is to sustain the conditions for free expression—including expressions that some find intolerable. Scholar Carol Vance clarifies that "obscenity is not a property of images but a condition of perception."⁸ What offends is not the image itself but the viewer's interpretive frame. To legislate against offense is therefore to legislate against perception, to enforce a single moral standard over a diverse citizenry.

When Congress imposed "decency" requirements on the NEA, it transformed subjective discomfort into state censorship. The result was a narrowing of public imagination. As Harriet Senie argues, public art should be evaluated by its "capacity to provoke civic dialogue."⁹

⁶ Stavans and Gracia, "On Desecration," 589.

⁷ Elisabetta Povoledo, "Pope Hosts Artists in Sistine Chapel, Even Some Who Attracted Controversy," *New York Times*, June 23, 2023.

⁸ Carol Vance, "Misunderstanding Obscenity," *Art in America* 78, no. 5 (May 1990): 40.

⁹ Harriet Senie, "Responsible Criticism: Evaluating Public Art," *Sculpture* 22, no. 10 (2003): 22.

Serrano's photograph achieved precisely that, yet politicians treated provocation as failure rather than success. By defining civic virtue as the absence of controversy, they denied art its democratic purpose. The same impulse drives today's campaigns to ban books, defund museums, or remove "divisive" monuments. Whether labeled decency, tradition, or protection, these gestures of censorship spring from the same anxiety: the fear that public space might reflect more than one truth.

Opponents of Serrano's defenders often claim that because art is funded by citizens, it must reflect "shared values." They argue that transgressive art divides rather than unites, and that a democracy cannot sustain works that offend the moral majority. But this logic misconstrues the nature of both art and democracy. As Kwon insists, "site-specific art's critical value lies in its exposure of conflict."¹⁰ Democracy is not agreement but engagement—the willingness to confront difference in public view. When *Piss Christ* sparked outrage, it demonstrated that engagement was still possible; citizens still cared enough to argue. To demand harmony from publicly funded art is to misunderstand its function. Public space, Senie reminds us, "is inherently contested."¹¹ A work like *Piss Christ* fulfills that mandate not by soothing viewers but by forcing them to wrestle with their own convictions.

Seen in this light, *Piss Christ* dramatizes democracy's discomfort with disagreement. Its glow—warm, almost devotional—invites viewers into contemplation, even as its title thrusts them back into disgust. The image holds both impulses in tension, much like democratic society itself. To defund or censor such work is to capitulate to fear, to imagine that unity can only exist through silence. Yet the mission of the NEA has always been to support "the diversity of

¹⁰ Kwon, *One Place After Another*, 80.

¹¹ Senie, "Responsible Criticism," 24.

expression that is the hallmark of American culture.”¹² When governments restrict funding based on offense, they undermine that very principle. They imply that only agreeable speech deserves visibility, that pluralism must be pruned to fit majority taste.

The endurance of *Piss Christ* in public memory proves otherwise. Decades after its creation, it continues to provoke conversation, scholarship, and reflection. It reminds us that offense is not a failure of art but evidence of its vitality. Serrano’s photograph may still unsettle viewers, but its endurance affirms that discomfort can coexist with reverence. If faith can survive immersion in urine, perhaps democracy can survive offense. The work’s paradoxical beauty—its serenity born of desecration—embodies the tension that sustains both art and freedom. To look at *Piss Christ* is to be reminded that the sacred and the profane, like agreement and dissent, are inseparable in any living culture. By embracing that coexistence, we preserve not only the integrity of art but the health of the democratic experiment itself.

¹² National Endowment for the Arts, “Mission Statement,” Washington, DC, 1965.

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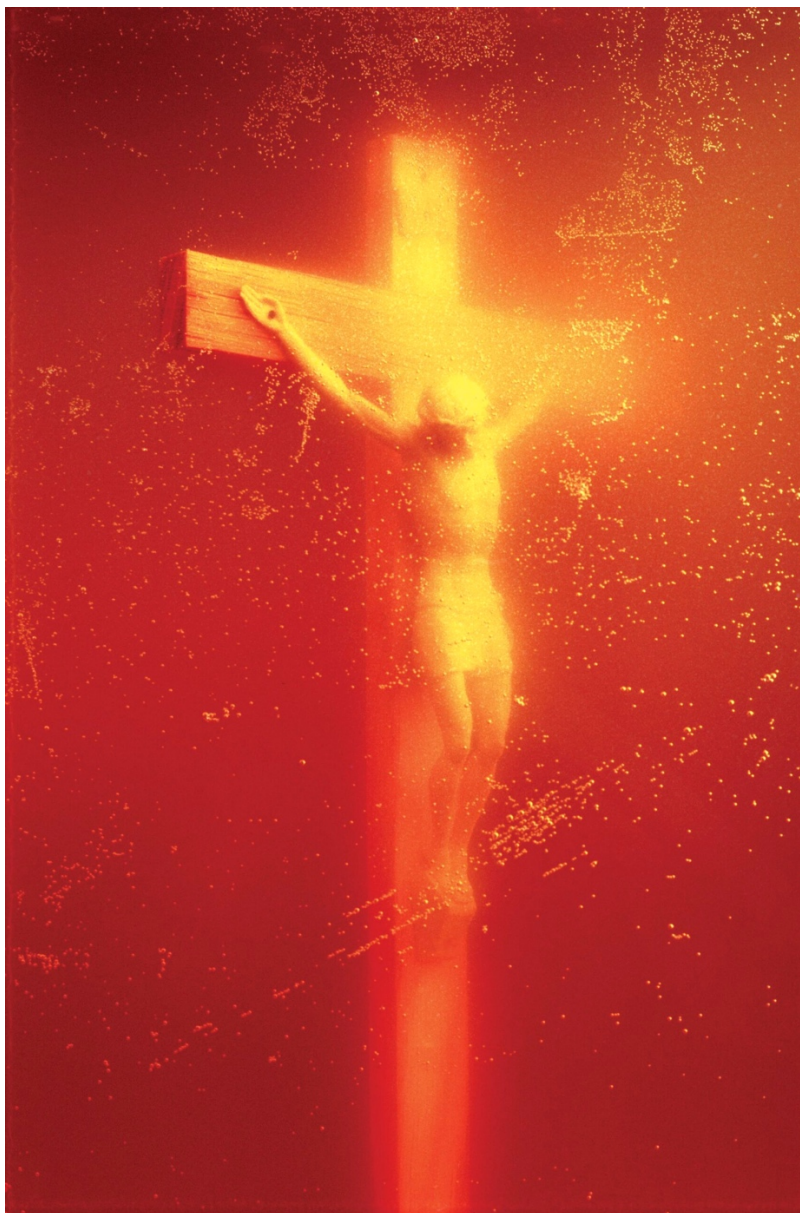


Figure 1. Andres Serrano, Piss Christ, 1987